now among the documents presented in the legal dispute, the Pipon objected to the "construction of a shrine belonging to another religion" which destroyed "the sanctity of this holy lake" (Gurudongmar) and invoked the Lachen-pa tribal community's desire to "preserve our ancient Buddhist tradition".

Before long, the state's forest department conducted a survey and declared the structure at the sacred lake an "unauthorised construction". In 1998, the chief secretary recorded his opinion that the 'gurudwara' was in contravention of both the Forest Conservation Act of 1980 and the Places of Worship Act of 1991, prompting the appointment of a committee to investigate the growing local controversy. By 2001, an apparent resolution was reached, providing for the building at Gurudongmar to be handed over to the (Buddhist) Lachen monastery, which would appoint a caretaker monk for the summer months when the site was habitable (given the extreme elevation) while the army would provide "logistical support".

From this point, however, the narratives of the two sides diverge into the familiar template of more famous 'mandir-masjid' disputes. The Buddhist party claims that persons unknown took to installing (non-Buddhist) "items" when the Gurudongmar structure was unattended. The Sikhs accuse the locals of having desecrated sacred objects by depositing them on the road in Chungthang and of denying pilgrims access to the holy lake. By 2017, the dispute reached the Supreme Court, which ordered the customary return to a status quo. This was followed by a writ petition in the High Court of Sikkim, filed by the 'Sri Guru Singh Sabha', seeking restoration of what they claim was a gurudwara, a plea the respondents, 'the State of Sikkim & Others' opposed.

Since then, the temperature of this high-altitude dispute has continued to rise. In 2019, the Sikkim government opposed live broadcasting of the court proceedings, in the interest of "national security", while Grewal complained of "Chinese spies" instigating the Lachenpas. In 2020, the then central government minister for food processing, Harsimrat Kaur Badal, tweeted her plea for the protection of what she puzzlingly described as the "Historic gurudwara Gurudongmar Sahib". And, as recently as February this year, in the run-up to assembly elections in Punjab, home minister Amit Shah reportedly held a meeting with the Jathedar of the Akal Takht in Amritsar where "the protection of Sikh Shrines", including Gurudwara Gurudongmar, was discussed.

Meanwhile, 500 km to the east of Gurudongmar, in the town of Mechuka, Arunachal Pradesh, representatives of the native Memba community, who are also Buddhists, have sought the government's assistance to reclaim 'Pema Shelphu', a sacred cave that they claim

Buddhists complain that outsiders installed Sikh religious 'items' when the structure at Gurudongmar was unattended

has been illegally furnished by army men with Sikh religious symbols and redesignated 'Taposthan Pemoshubhu.' And in distant Ladakh, at the other end of the Himalaya, similar shrines are the focus of quieter but persistent frictions between local Buddhists and Sikh representatives. A sacred rock—once known by Buddhists as 'Lama Guru' and now housed in the army-run 'Pathar Sahib Gurudwara'—and a tree, once revered as 'Tsug Tor'—sprung from the walking stick of a legendary lama—now proclaimed as Guru Nanak's miraculous toothbrush tree by the adjoining 'Gurudwara Datun Sahib'. Perhaps all these places—a lake, a cave, a rock, a tree—could have been quietly worshipped in the name of more than one God or Guru. But why philosophise? Whether Sikh or Buddhist, they now seem destined for the monumentalism of brick and mortar, paint and marble that defines our national cult of competitive communalism. ■ **–Kai Friese**



NEW DELHI

PURANA SHIV MANDIR

CREEPING TEMPLES

The iconic Charminar, an imposing edifice built to mark the founding of Hyderabad by Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah in 1591, has withstood the vagaries of time. But since the late '60s, below the southeastern minaret, a religious structure has been taking shape under a canopy. Perhaps to keep the peace, the police and ASI have mostly been noncommittal about the temple.

Answering an RTI query in 2012, the ASI stated, "As per the AMASR (Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains) Act, 1958, Rules 1959, AMASR Act, 2010 (Amendment & Validation), the construction of the temple adjacent to the southeastern minar of the